CHAPTER 14 Federal System

Political scientists have classified governments into unitary and federal on the basis of the nature of relations between the national government and the regional governments. By definition, a unitary government is one in which all the powers are vested in the national government and the regional governments, if at all exist, derive their authority from the national government. A federal government, on the other hand, is one in which powers are divided between the national government and the regional governments by the Constitution itself and both operate in their respective jurisdictions independently. Britain, France, Japan, China, Italy, Norway, Sweden and so on have a unitary model of government while the US, Switzerland, Australia, Canada, Russia, Brazil, Argentina and so on have a federal model of government. In a federal model, the national government is known as the Federal government or the Central government or the Union government and the regional government is known as the state government or the provincial government.

The specific features of the federal and unitary governments are mentioned in a comparative manner in Table 14.1.

The term 'federation' is drived from a Latin word *foedus* which means 'treaty' or 'agreement'. Thus, a federation is a new state (political system) which is formed through a treaty or an agreement between the various units. The units of a federation are known by various names like states (as in US) or cantons (as in Switzerland) or provinces (as in Canada) or republics (as in Russia).

A federation can be formed in two ways, that is, by way of integration or by way of disintegration. In the first case, a number of militarily weak or economically backward states (independent) come together to form a big and a strong union, as for example, the US. In the second case, a big unitary state is converted into a federation by granting autonomy to the provinces to promote regional interest (for example, Canada). The US is the first and the oldest federation in the world. It was formed in 1787 following the American Revolution (1775–83). It comprises 50 states (originally 13 states) and is taken as the model of federation. The Canadian Federation, comprising 10 provinces (originally 4 provinces) is also quite old—formed in 1867.

Table 14.1 Comparing Features of Federal and Unitary Governments

Federal Government	Unitary Government
1. Dual Government (that is, national government and regional government)	1. Single government, that is, the national government which may create regional governments
2. Written Constitution	2. Constitution may be written (France) or unwritten (Britain)